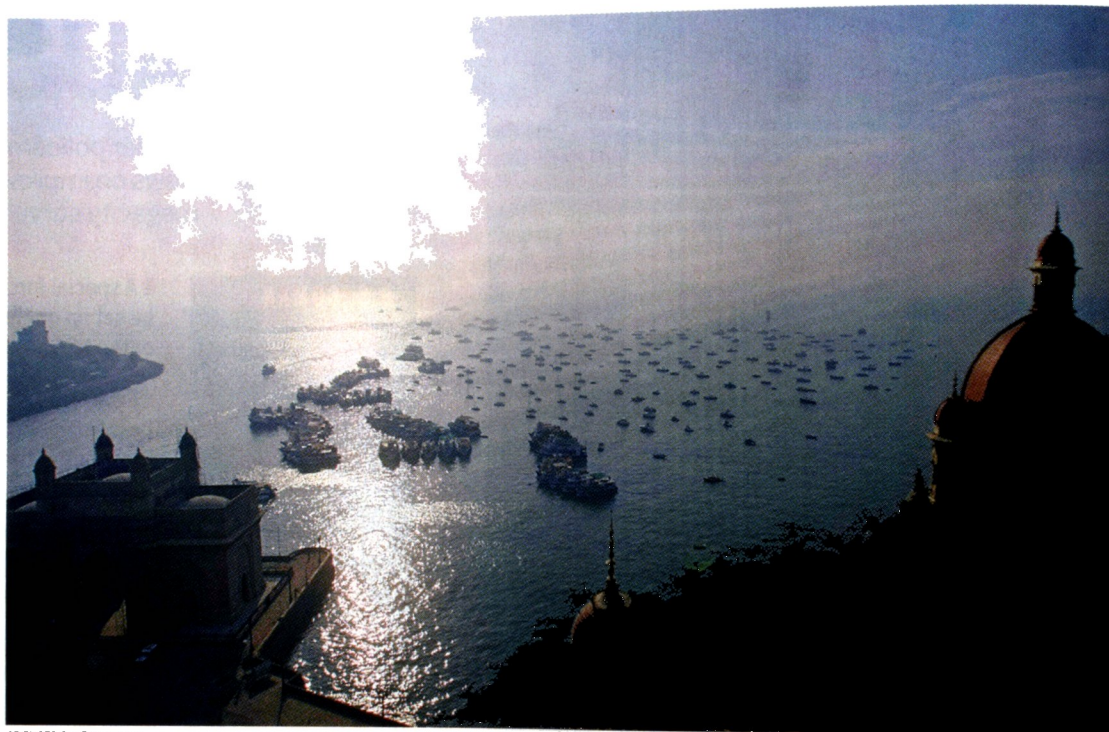




AP PHOTO/GAUTAM SINGH



PLUGGING Vulnerable Zones

Indian borders continue to be porous. With attacks from the sea posing a new threat, there's a need for watertight coastal security strategy.

India is a maritime nation. This is a truism which needs frequent repetition because of the sea blindness afflicted upon us by centuries of looking out towards land. A legacy of over a millennia of invaders pouring in across the land frontiers.

Even today, India's unresolved borders with three of its neighbours only drain national security resources and occupy mindspace. It is, however, the 7,600-km coastline that holds the key to the nation's prosperity. The 13 major ports and 183

minor ports—through which over 90 per cent of India's trade by volume and 75 per cent by cost and all its imported crude oil passes through—are the maritime gateways without which India's economic miracle would not have taken off. Sixty-six per cent of India's domestic crude comes from the sea.

India is the third-largest fish-producing nation in the world, with over three lakh fishing boats. There is thus an inextricable link between maritime commerce, maritime security and national security. This link

was fiendishly exploited by the terrorists on November 26 who sailed into India's economic capital using a commandeered fishing trawler, to wreak havoc. It was economic terrorism at its worst.

The targets chosen were not only geographically disparate but also diverse sectors—tourism, hospitality, economy and diplomatic relations. Terrorists easily penetrated into a twin layer of security—the shoreline upto 12 nautical miles patrolled by the state police, 12 to 200 nautical miles po-